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URL of this page: <https://medlineplus.gov/postpartumcare.html>

Postpartum Care

Also called: Post-pregnancy health

Taking home a new baby is one of the happiest times in a woman's life. But it also presents both physical and emotional challenges. :

- Get as much rest as possible. You may find that all you can do is eat, sleep, and care for your baby. And that is perfectly okay. You will have spotting or bleeding, like a menstrual period, off and on for up to six weeks.
- You might also have swelling in your legs and feet, feel constipated, have menstrual-like cramping. Even if you are not breastfeeding, you can have milk leaking from your nipples, and your breasts might feel full, tender, or uncomfortable.

- Follow your doctor's instructions on how much activity, like climbing stairs or walking, you can do for the next few weeks.
- Doctors usually recommend that you abstain from sexual intercourse for four to six weeks after birth.

In addition to physical changes, you may feel sad or have the "baby blues." If you are extremely sad or are unable to care for yourself or your baby, you might have a serious condition called **postpartum depression** [<https://medlineplus.gov/postpartumdepression.html>] .

Dept. of Health and Human Services Office on Women's Health

Start Here

- **Pregnant and Postpartum Women** [<https://www.cdc.gov/earher/pregnant-postpartum/>]
 (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention)
- **Recovering from Birth** [<https://womenshealth.gov/pregnancy/childbirth-and-beyond/recovering-birth>]
(Department of Health and Human Services, Office on Women's Health)
Also in Spanish [<https://espanol.womenshealth.gov/pregnancy/childbirth-and-beyond/recovering-birth>]
- **Recovering from Delivery** [<https://kidshealth.org/en/parents/recovering-delivery.html>] (Nemours Foundation)
Also in Spanish [<https://kidshealth.org/es/parents/recovering-delivery.html>]
- **Your Body after Baby: The First 6 Weeks** [<https://www.marchofdimes.org/find-support/topics/postpartum/your-body-after-baby-first-6-weeks>] (March of Dimes Foundation)

Symptoms

- Signs and Symptoms of Urgent Maternal Warnings Signs [<https://www.cdc.gov/hearher/maternal-warning-signs/>] **Easy-to-Read** (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention)
Also in Spanish [https://www.cdc.gov/hearher/spanish/docs/pdf/hearher_women_palmcard_5x7-spanish-508c.pdf]
- Warning Signs to Look for After Having a Baby [<https://www.marchofdimes.org/find-support/blog/warning-signs-to-look-after-having-baby-0>] (March of Dimes Foundation)

Related Issues

- Exercise after Pregnancy [<https://www.acog.org/womens-health/faqs/exercise-after-pregnancy>]
(American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists)
- Postpartum Birth Control [<https://www.acog.org/womens-health/faqs/postpartum-birth-control>]
(American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists)
- Providing Support for Pregnant or Postpartum Women [<https://www.cdc.gov/hearher/caring/>]
(Centers for Disease Control and Prevention)
- Your Postpartum Checkups [<https://www.marchofdimes.org/find-support/topics/postpartum/your-postpartum-checkups>] (March of Dimes Foundation)

Specifics

- Infections After Childbirth [<https://www.merckmanuals.com/home/women-s-health-issues/postpartum-care/infections-after-childbirth>] (Merck & Co., Inc.)

- **Mastitis** [<https://www.mayoclinic.org/diseases-conditions/mastitis/symptoms-causes/syc-20374829?p=1>]
(Mayo Foundation for Medical Education and Research)
Also in Spanish [<https://www.mayoclinic.org/es/diseases-conditions/mastitis/symptoms-causes/syc-20374829?p=1>]

Clinical Trials

- **ClinicalTrials.gov: Postnatal Care** [<https://clinicaltrials.gov/search?cond=%22Postnatal+Care%22&aggFilters=status:not%20rec>]  (National Institutes of Health)
- **ClinicalTrials.gov: Postpartum Period** [<https://clinicaltrials.gov/search?cond=%22Postpartum+Period%22&aggFilters=status:not%20rec>]  (National Institutes of Health)
- **ClinicalTrials.gov: Puerperal Disorders** [<https://clinicaltrials.gov/search?cond=%22Puerperal+Disorders%22&aggFilters=status:not%20rec>]  (National Institutes of Health)

Journal Articles

References and abstracts from MEDLINE/PubMed (National Library of Medicine)

- **Article: A cluster-randomised controlled trial evaluating the effects of a blended care...**
[<https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pubmed/41780341>]
- **Article: Lifestyle Outcomes Six and Twelve Months After Hypertensive Disorders of Pregnancy:...**
[<https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pubmed/41754126>]
- **Article: Assessment of self-management empowerment program on sense of coherence, self-efficacy and...**
[<https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pubmed/41663514>]

- Postpartum Care -- see more articles [<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/?term=%22Postnatal+Care%22%5Bmajr%3Anoexp%5D+OR+%22Puerperal+Disorders%22%5Bmajr%3Anoexp%5D+OR+%22Postpartum+Period%22%5Bmajr%3Anoexp%5D+AND+humans%5Bmh%5D+AND+english%5Bla%5D+AND+%22last+1+Year%22+%5Bedat%5D+AND+%28patient+education+handout%5Bpt%5D+OR+guideline%5Bpt%5D+OR+clinical+trial%5Bpt%5D%29++NOT+%28letter%5Bpt%5D+OR+case+reports%5Bpt%5D+OR+editorial%5Bpt%5D+OR+comment%5Bpt%5D%29+AND+free+full+text%5Bsb%5D+>]

Find an Expert

- Eunice Kennedy Shriver National Institute of Child Health and Human Development [<https://www.nichd.nih.gov/>] 
Also in Spanish [<https://espanol.nichd.nih.gov/>]

Patient Handouts

- After vaginal delivery - in the hospital [<https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000629.htm>]
(Medical Encyclopedia)
Also in Spanish [<https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/patientinstructions/000629.htm>]
- Losing weight after pregnancy [<https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000586.htm>]
(Medical Encyclopedia)
Also in Spanish [<https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/patientinstructions/000586.htm>]
- Questions to ask your doctor about going home with your baby [<https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000949.htm>] (Medical Encyclopedia)
Also in Spanish [<https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/patientinstructions/000949.htm>]

- Questions to ask your doctor about post pregnancy care
[<https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000961.htm>] (Medical Encyclopedia)
Also in Spanish [<https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/patientinstructions/000961.htm>]
- Vaginal delivery - discharge [<https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000628.htm>] (Medical Encyclopedia)
Also in Spanish [<https://medlineplus.gov/spanish/ency/patientinstructions/000628.htm>]



MEDICAL ENCYCLOPEDIA

After vaginal delivery - in the hospital [<https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000629.htm>]

Episiotomy - aftercare [<https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000483.htm>]

Losing weight after pregnancy [<https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000586.htm>]

Questions to ask your doctor about post pregnancy care
[<https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000961.htm>]

Vaginal delivery - discharge [<https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000628.htm>]

Related Health Topics

Postpartum Depression [<https://medlineplus.gov/postpartumdepression.html>]

Other Languages

Find health information in languages other than English
[<https://medlineplus.gov/languages/postpartumcare.html>] on *Postpartum Care*

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[<https://medlineplus.gov/criteria.html>] .

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